

NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF MODERN
LANGUAGES

Assignment # 02



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Subject: Psychology

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Summary of documentary

(The Social Dilemma)

"The Social Dilemma" is a 2020 Netflix documentary that explores the harmful effects of social media on individuals and society. The interviews with the executives and engineers from major social media companies such as Google, Facebook, and Twitter, who discuss the ways in which these platforms manipulate user behavior for profit. The documentary examines how algorithms are used to keep users engaged with social media. "The Social Dilemma" presents a powerful argument for rethinking our relationship with social media and calls for greater accountability from social media companies.

Major issues

"The Social Dilemma" highlights several major issues related to social media and its impact on individuals and society. These include:

Manipulation of user behavior:

The documentary explains how social media companies use algorithms to analyse user data and manipulate their behavior to keep them engaged on the platform for as long as possible.

Addiction:

Social media is designed to be addictive, and that this addiction can have negative effects on mental health.

Disinformation:

The documentary discusses how social media can be used to spread false information and propaganda, and how this can have harmful consequences for democracy and society as a whole.

Privacy:

The film highlights concerns around data privacy, arguing that social media companies collect vast amounts of personal data without users' explicit consent and use it to target ads and manipulate behavior.

Psychological factors in the documentary

"The Social Dilemma" discusses several psychological factors that are involved in the design of social media platforms and their impact on users. These include:

The Dopamine Effect:

Social media platforms are designed to trigger the release of dopamine in the brain, a chemical associated with pleasure and reward. This can lead to addictive behavior and a desire for more likes, shares, and comments.

Social Comparison:

Social media encourages users to compare themselves to others, leading to feelings of insecurity and anxiety. Users may feel pressure to present a certain image online, leading to a distorted sense of self and an emphasis on external validation.

Cognitive Dissonance:

Social media can create cognitive dissonance when users are exposed to conflicting information and opinions. This can lead to confusion and a loss of trust in traditional sources of information.

Relate to real life

"The Social Dilemma" is highly relevant to real life, as social media has become an integral part of our daily lives. The documentary highlights the ways in which social media platforms manipulate user behavior for profit, and the potential negative consequences for individuals and society as a whole. Many of the issues discussed in the film, such as addiction, polarization, disinformation, and privacy, are real-life problems that have been widely reported in the media.

Relate to software engineering

The issues highlighted in "The Social Dilemma" are relevant to software engineering, particularly in the design and development of social media platforms. Software engineers play a crucial role in creating the algorithms and features that shape user behavior on these platforms.

One of the main concerns raised in the documentary is the use of data and algorithms to manipulate user behavior, such as the dopamine effect and confirmation bias. Software engineers are responsible for developing these algorithms and designing features that keep users engaged and addicted to the platform. They must consider the potential impact of these design choices on the user and on society as a whole.

In addition, the documentary highlights the importance of privacy and data protection in the design of social media platforms. Software engineers must design platforms with privacy in mind, using secure data storage, encryption, and other techniques to protect user data.

My opinion on the issue

My opinion about the documentary is that, the documentary raises important concerns about the impact of social media on individuals and society. Social media platforms are designed to keep users engaged and addicted, using sophisticated algorithms that analyse user data and manipulate their behavior. This can have negative consequences for mental health, privacy, and democracy.